

AP MUSIC THEORY · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 3-PART EXAM · AURAL + WRITTEN + SIGHT-SINGING

About this exam. AP Music Theory is unique: it tests **aural skills, written music theory, and sight-singing all in one exam**. Half is multiple-choice (aural + non-aural); the other half is FRQ including melodic dictation, harmonic dictation, four-part voice leading, and **2 sight-singing performances you record**. **You CAN'T cram this exam**. Aural skills and sight-singing require months of consistent practice — but written theory + part-writing CAN be sharpened in weeks.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	Approximate composite score breakdown
3 (PASS)	Solid on intervals/key sigs/chord ID; partial dictation; basic part-writing; sight-sing simple diatonic with rhythm errors
4	Reliable dictation accuracy; good part-writing minus a few voice-leading slips; sight-sing accurate diatonic w/ small chromatic
5	Near-perfect dictation; clean part-writing; fluent sight-singing including chromatic notes + modulations

EXAM STRUCTURE — three sections

SECTION I — Multiple Choice (~45% of score)

Part A: AURAL (~30 min) — listen to passages, answer questions

Part B: NON-AURAL (~40 min) — read score, identify intervals, chords, etc.

Total: 75 questions

SECTION II — Free Response (~45% of score)

Q1-Q2: Melodic dictation

Q3-Q4: Harmonic dictation

Q5: Part-writing from figured bass

Q6: Part-writing from Roman numerals

Q7: Compose a melody

SECTION III — Sight-Singing (~10% of score, but HUGE per question)

Q8 + Q9: 2 melodies, ~30 sec prep each, ~30 sec to sing each

Recorded with your own voice

THE 8 UNITS — by exam content

#	Unit	Weight	Focus
1	Pitch + Rhythm Foundations	8–12%	Notation, clefs, scales, intervals, time signatures
2	Minor Scales & Key Signatures	5–10%	Natural/harmonic/melodic minor; relative + parallel
3	Triads + Seventh Chords	10–14%	Quality, inversions, figured bass symbols
4	Aural & Written Composition Basics	5–8%	Phrasing, cadences
5	Voice Leading & Harmonic Function	10–14%	Tonic/predominant/dominant; voice leading rules
6	Harmonic Progressions, Cadences, Phrase Structure	13–17%	Period, sentence; cadence types (PAC, IAC, half, deceptive)
7	Modes + Chromatic Harmony	12–16%	Modes, secondary dominants, modulation
8	Modulation + Form	13–18%	Closely-related keys; binary, ternary, sonata structures

KEY INSIGHT [5] Units 5-8 = ~50% of the exam. Voice leading + harmonic function + chromatic harmony + modulation appear together on FRQs (especially Q5/Q6 part-writing). Don't get stuck on basics — push to chromatic harmony for the 5.

PAGE 2 | PITCH · INTERVALS · SCALES · KEY SIGNATURES

Notation Basics [3]

- **Treble clef [3]:** lines E G B D F ("Every Good Boy Does Fine"); spaces F A C E.
- **Bass clef [3]:** lines G B D F A ("Good Boys Do Fine Always"); spaces A C E G.
- **Alto/tenor C clefs [4]:** middle line is middle C. Common in part-writing for inner voices.
- **Ledger lines [3]:** extend staff above/below. Practice reading 2-3 ledger lines fluently.

Intervals [3]/[4]

INTERVAL = distance between two notes

STEP 1: count line/space numbers (inclusive). C → E = 3rd. C → G = 5th.

STEP 2: determine quality:

P (Perfect) – 1, 4, 5, 8 (only)

M/m (Major/minor) – 2, 3, 6, 7 (only)

A (Augmented) – half-step bigger than M or P

d (Diminished) – half-step smaller than m or P

COMPOUND INTERVALS (> octave): subtract 7 (e.g., 10th = 3rd + octave)

INVERSION RULE: P↔P, M↔m, A↔d, sum to 9.

M3 inverts to m6. P5 inverts to P4. A4 inverts to d5.

Major + Minor Scales [3]/[4]

MAJOR SCALE: W-W-H-W-W-W-H (whole/half steps from tonic)

C major: C D E F G A B C

MINOR SCALES (3 forms):

NATURAL minor: W-H-W-W-H-W-W (relative minor of major)

A natural minor: A B C D E F G A

HARMONIC minor: W-H-W-W-H-A²-H (raised 7th – leading tone)

A harmonic minor: A B C D E F G[#] A

MELODIC minor: ascending W-H-W-W-W-W-H (raised 6th + 7th up)
descending = natural minor

A melodic minor up: A B C D E F[#] G[#] A

A melodic minor down: A G F E D C B A

Key Signatures + Circle of Fifths [3]/[4]

CIRCLE OF FIFTHS – sharps add (clockwise):

C → G → D → A → E → B → F[#] → C[#]

0 1[#] 2[#] 3[#] 4[#] 5[#] 6[#] 7[#]

Order of sharps: F C G D A E B ("Fat Cats Go Down Alleys Eating Beans")

Order of flats: B E A D G C F (reverse: "BEAD" + "Greatest Common Factor")

RELATIVE MINOR: 6th degree of major (or down a m3).

C major / A minor share 0 sharps/flats.

G major / E minor share 1 sharp.

PARALLEL minor: same TONIC, different mode (C major / C minor – 3 flats apart).

PAGE 3 | RHYTHM · METER · TIME SIGNATURES

Note + Rest Values [3]

Whole note (○) = 4 beats (in 4/4)
 Half note (J with stem hollow) = 2 beats
 Quarter note (J) = 1 beat
 Eighth note (♪) = 1/2 beat
 Sixteenth (♫) = 1/4 beat

DOTTED NOTE = original + half its value (dotted half = 3 beats)

TIE = adds two notes together across barline

TRIPLET = 3 notes in space of 2 (or 6 in space of 4, etc.)

Time Signatures — simple vs compound [3]/[4]

Type	Description + examples
Simple meter [3]	Beat divides into 2 (then 4). Top number 2, 3, or 4. Each beat = quarter, half, or eighth.
Compound meter [3]/[4]	Beat divides into 3. Top numbers 6, 9, 12 (= 2, 3, 4 beats × 3 subdivisions). Each beat = dotted note.
6/8 example [4]	Compound duple. 2 beats per measure, each beat = dotted quarter (3 eighth notes).
3/4 example [4]	Simple triple. 3 beats per measure, each beat = quarter (2 eighth notes).
Asymmetric [5]	5/8, 7/8, etc. Mix of duple + triple groupings.

Conducting + Beat Patterns [3]

- **Strong beats** [3]: beat 1 in any meter; beat 3 in 4/4; downbeat of any group.
- **Weak beats** [3]: beat 2 + 4 in 4/4; offbeats.
- **Syncopation** [4] = emphasis on weak beats or offbeats (jazz, ragtime, modern pop).
- **Hemiola** [5] = 3-against-2 rhythmic feel (e.g., 6/8 sounding like 3/4).

KEY INSIGHT [4] **Aural identification of meter.** Listen for accent patterns. Strong-weak-strong-weak = duple. Strong-weak-weak = triple. Compound meter has lilting subdivisions in 3s.

PAGE 4 | TRIADS · SEVENTH CHORDS · INVERSIONS · ROMAN NUMERALS**Triad Qualities [3]**

Major triad: M3 + m3 (e.g., C E G)
 Minor triad: m3 + M3 (e.g., C E^b G)
 Diminished triad: m3 + m3 (e.g., C E^b G^b)
 Augmented triad: M3 + M3 (e.g., C E G[#])

ROMAN NUMERALS in major:

I – major (tonic) ii – minor (supertonic)
 iii – minor IV – major (subdominant)
 V – major (dominant) vi – minor (submediant)
 vii^o – diminished (leading tone)

ROMAN NUMERALS in minor:

i – minor ii^o – diminished
 III – major iv – minor
 V – major (raised 7) VI – major
 vii^o – diminished VII – major (natural 7)

Inversions + Figured Bass [3]/[4]**TRIAD INVERSIONS:**

Root position: no figured bass numbers (or 5/3)
 1st inversion: 6 (6/3) – 3rd in bass
 2nd inversion: 6/4 – 5th in bass

SEVENTH CHORD INVERSIONS:

Root position: 7 (7/5/3)
 1st inversion: 6/5 – 3rd in bass
 2nd inversion: 4/3 – 5th in bass
 3rd inversion: 4/2 – 7th in bass

EXAMPLE: "V6/5" = dominant 7 chord in 1st inversion
 "ii6" = supertonic in 1st inversion

Seventh Chord Qualities [3]/[4]

Type	Construction
Major 7 (M7) [3]	Major triad + Major 7th. C-E-G-B.
Dominant 7 (V⁷) [3]/[4]	Major triad + minor 7th. G-B-D-F (in C major).
Minor 7 (m7) [3]/[4]	Minor triad + minor 7th. D-F-A-C.
Half-diminished (ø⁷) [4]/[5]	Diminished triad + minor 7th. B-D-F-A.
Fully diminished (°⁷) [5]	Diminished triad + diminished 7th. B-D-F-A ^b .

KEY INSIGHT [4] Identifying chords aurally. Major = bright/stable. Minor = sad/melancholy. Diminished = tense, unresolved. Augmented = otherworldly, suspended. Dominant 7th = strong pull toward tonic. Train your ear with these emotional fingerprints.

PAGE 5 | VOICE LEADING · PART-WRITING RULES (Q5 + Q6)

Q5 + Q6 = the part-writing FRQs. You write SATB (soprano-alto-tenor-bass) realizations of figured bass (Q5) or Roman numeral progressions (Q6). **Voice-leading rules are graded harshly** — each error = -1.

SATB voice ranges [3]/[4]

Soprano: C4 (middle C) up to G5
 Alto: G3 up to D5
 Tenor: C3 up to G4
 Bass: E2 up to D4

CHECK: each note must fit its voice's range.

CHECK: spacing — no more than an OCTAVE between adjacent upper voices
 (S-A, A-T must be ≤ octave; T-B can be larger)

Part-Writing Rules — the BIG ones [3]/[4]/[5]**AVOID:**

1. PARALLEL 5THS or PARALLEL OCTAVES between any two voices — fatal error!
2. DOUBLED LEADING TONE (degree 7) — never double, always resolve UP to tonic
3. Voice CROSSING (alto goes above soprano, etc.) — avoid
4. LARGE LEAPS (more than P5 in upper voices, except sometimes bass)
5. UNRESOLVED 7TH — chord 7th MUST resolve down by step
6. TRITONES not properly resolved (in V⁷, F → E and B → C)

PREFER:

Common tones held in same voice when possible
 Stepwise motion in upper voices (S, A, T)
 Contrary motion between bass + soprano
 Resolve chord 7th DOWN by step
 Resolve leading tone (degree 7) UP to tonic in V → I

Voice-Leading the V → I Cadence [3]/[4]**CLASSIC V → I (in C major):**

Bass: G → C (root motion)
 Tenor: D → C (5th down by step OR up to tonic)
 Alto: B → C (LEADING TONE → tonic, up by half-step)
 Soprano: G → E (or G→G for common tone)

KEY POINTS:

- Leading tone (B) MUST go to tonic (C) up by half-step
- Chord 7th of V⁷ (F if V⁷=GBDF) resolves DOWN by step to E
- Bass moves by leap (G→C); upper voices move by step
- Tonic chord may have INCOMPLETE 5th (no G, just C-E-C or C-C-E)

KEY INSIGHT [4] On part-writing FRQs, AP gives partial credit per chord. Each chord scored 0/1. Even if voice-leading errors creep in, getting CORRECT NOTES (right Roman numeral spelling) earns most of the points.

Common Q5/Q6 deductions [4]/[5]

- **[4] Parallel 5ths/8ves** — automatic deductions. Check every voice pair every transition.
- **[4] Doubled leading tone** — never double scale degree 7 in V or vii°.
- **[4] Wrong inversion** — figured bass tells you which chord member is in the bass. Read the numbers.
- **[5] Direct (hidden) 5ths/8ves** — outer voices arrive at perfect interval by similar motion. Less severe but still penalized.
- **[5] Cross relations** — chromatic alteration in different voices in successive chords (B and B^b in different parts).

PAGE 6 | CADENCES · PHRASE STRUCTURE · HARMONIC PROGRESSION

Cadence Types [3]/[4]

Cadence	Description
Authentic (PAC) [3]	V → I, both in root position, soprano on tonic. Strongest closure.
Imperfect Authentic (IAC) [3]/[4]	V → I but missing a PAC requirement (e.g., soprano on 3rd or 5th).
Half [3]	Any → V. Phrase ends inconclusively on dominant. Common at end of antecedent phrase.
Plagal [3]	IV → I. "Amen cadence." Found in church music, hymns.
Deceptive [4]/[5]	V → vi (instead of expected I). Surprises listener; delays closure.
Phrygian half [5]	iv ⁶ → V in minor. Older sound.

Phrase Structure [3]/[4]

PHRASE = musical thought ending in a cadence (typically 4 measures).

PERIOD = two phrases, antecedent + consequent.

Antecedent: ends on HALF cadence (or weaker authentic).

Consequent: ends on PAC.

"Question-Answer" or "Open-Closed" feel.

PARALLEL period: both phrases start with same melodic material.

CONTRASTING period: phrases start with different melodic material.

SENTENCE [5]: short basic idea (1-2 measures), repetition (1-2 measures), continuation/cadence (longer). Common in Beethoven.

Harmonic Function [3]/[4]

TONIC FUNCTION (T):	I, vi, iii	"home"
PREDOMINANT (PD):	ii, IV, vi	"departure"
DOMINANT FUNCTION (D):	V, vii ^o	"tension, pulls back to tonic"

STANDARD progression: T → PD → D → T

Examples: I → IV → V → I

I → ii⁶ → V⁷ → I

I → vi → ii → V → I ("circle of fifths" progression)

UNDERSTANDING this lets you predict + analyze progressions quickly.

KEY INSIGHT [5] On harmonic dictation FRQs, **FUNCTION first, exact chord second.** "Predominant moving to dominant" is half the work. Then identify whether ii or IV, V or vii^o, etc. by sonority + bass note.

PAGE 7 | MODES · CHROMATIC HARMONY · MODULATION

The 7 Modes [4]/[5]

Each mode = major scale starting on different scale degree.
In C major scale (no sharps/flats):

Ionian (C-C):	bright, identical to MAJOR
Dorian (D-D):	minor + raised 6th – folk, jazz
Phrygian (E-E):	minor + lowered 2nd – Spanish, dark
Lydian (F-F):	major + raised 4th – bright, dreamy
Mixolydian (G-G):	major + lowered 7th – bluesy, rock
Aeolian (A-A):	natural minor
Locrian (B-B):	half-diminished – rare, unstable

ID by characteristic note vs major/minor scale.

Secondary Dominants [4]/[5]

V/x = the dominant of x ("five of x ")

EXAMPLE: in C major, $V/V = D$ major (the dominant of G, which is V of C).
D-F#-A. The F# is the chromatic note that signals secondary dominant.

COMMON SECONDARY DOMINANTS:

$V/V \rightarrow V \rightarrow I$	"five of five"
$V/IV \rightarrow IV \rightarrow I$	(which makes IV briefly act like a tonic)
$V/vi \rightarrow vi$	(briefly tonicizes vi)
$V^7/ii \rightarrow ii$ (in major)	

Spotting on a score: ACCIDENTAL on note that's not in key signature.

Modulation [4]/[5]

- **[4] Modulation** = changing keys mid-piece. **Closely related keys** = differ by ≤ 1 sharp/flat.
- **[4] Common modulation destinations** from major: dominant (V), relative minor (vi), subdominant (IV).
- **[5] Pivot chord modulation**: a chord exists in BOTH old + new keys. Reinterpret then resolve in new key.
- **[5] Common chromatic chords**: Neapolitan (bII in 1st inv = N^6), Italian/French/German augmented 6ths.

Aural identification of modulation [5]

[5] On harmonic dictation, modulation often appears in the second half. Listen for: (a) repeated dominant motion suggesting a new tonic, (b) cadence on a chord that ISN'T the original tonic, (c) accidentals signaling new key signature.

PAGE 8 | MELODIC + HARMONIC DICTATION · SIGHT-SINGING

Melodic Dictation (Q1 + Q2) [3]/[4]/[5]

YOU HEAR: a melody (8-12 notes) played multiple times.
YOU WRITE: the notes on staff.

STRATEGY:

1. FIRST listen: get the SHAPE – is it ascending, descending, lots of leaps? Identify the FIRST and LAST notes (often the tonic).
2. SECOND listen: catch the meter + rhythm.
3. THIRD-FIFTH listens: fill in pitches by interval from previous note.
4. CHECK: does the rhythm fit the meter? Does the melody outline the key?

TIP: write rhythms BELOW the staff first if helpful. Then add pitches.

Harmonic Dictation (Q3 + Q4) [3]/[4]/[5]

YOU HEAR: a chord progression (4-bar phrase, ~5-8 chords).
YOU WRITE: bass line + soprano melody + Roman numeral analysis.

STRATEGY:

1. FIRST listen: what KEY? Major/minor? Cadence at the end?
2. SECOND listen: catch the BASS line – usually moves stepwise or by 4ths/5ths.
3. THIRD listen: catch the SOPRANO melody – top voice.
4. FOURTH-FIFTH listens: identify Roman numerals based on bass + chord quality.

USE FUNCTION: T → PD → D → T progressions are predictable.

Common bass patterns:

- 1-5-1-5 (I-V-I-V)
- 1-6-4-5 (I-vi-IV-V)
- 1-4-1-5-1 (I-IV-I-V-I)

Sight-Singing (Q8 + Q9) [3]/[4]/[5]

You're given a melody you've never seen, get ~30 seconds to study it, then sing it into a recorder. Solfège (do-re-mi) or numbers (1-2-3) work — pick one and stick with it.

STRATEGY (during 30-sec prep):

1. Identify KEY + tonic (your "do").
2. SING the tonic chord (do-mi-sol-do) silently to lock pitch.
3. Scan for HARD spots: large leaps, accidentals, syncopation.
4. Practice those leaps using interval relationships.
5. Establish TEMPO – count off in your head before you start.

WHILE SINGING:

- Sing CONFIDENTLY, even if wrong – partial credit for rhythm + shape.
- If you slip pitch, KEEP GOING with adjusted relative pitch.
- Don't restart unless you have time – you only get the time given.

KEY INSIGHT [4] The most-rewarded sight-sing skill: **tonal anchoring**. Constantly mentally compare each note to TONIC. Don't think "up a 3rd, down a 5th" — think "sol, mi, do, re." Tonic-relative thinking is far more accurate than interval-by-interval.

Sight-singing scoring [4]/[5]

- [4] **Pitch accuracy** = primary criterion. Each pitch graded individually.
- [4] **Rhythm accuracy** = secondary. Right pitches, wrong rhythm = partial credit.
- [4] **Tempo + steadiness** = bonus. Steady tempo > frantic + accurate.
- [5] **Self-correction** = penalized. Singing through with confidence > stopping to fix.

PAGE 9 | EXAM-DAY STRATEGY · COMMON MISTAKES · TIME MGMT

Time strategy [3]/[4]

TOTAL EXAM: ~3 hours

Section I (MCQ):

Aural (~30 min for 35 q): listen carefully, can't replay outside listens.
Non-aural (~40 min for 40 q): read score-based questions.

Section II (FRQ written, ~80 min):

Q1-Q2 melodic dictation: ~12 min (replays included)
Q3-Q4 harmonic dictation: ~16 min (replays included)
Q5 part-writing figured bass: ~15 min
Q6 part-writing Roman numerals: ~15 min
Q7 melody composition: ~10 min

Section II (Sight-singing):

Q8 + Q9 each: ~30 sec study + ~30 sec performance

Mistakes that cap your score at 3 [3]/[4]

- **Misreading clefs** — practice alto/tenor C-clefs if part-writing requires.
- **Wrong key signature interpretation** — count sharps/flats carefully.
- **Doubling leading tone in part-writing** — never. Always resolve up.
- **Skipping rhythm in dictation** — write rhythm first, pitches second.
- **Not singing tonic chord before sight-sing** — anchors your pitch.

Mistakes that cap at 4 [4]/[5]

- **Parallel 5ths/8ves in part-writing** — automatic deductions; check every voice pair.
- **Missing secondary dominants** — accidental on a non-key tone signals V/x.
- **Missing modulation** in harmonic dictation — listen for cadence on non-tonic.
- **Wrong inversion notation** — figured bass numbers tell you which chord member is in bass.
- **Restarting sight-sing** — costs time, you don't get more.

Last-30-Days Plan [4]/[5]

WEEK 1: Drill INTERVALS + TRIADS daily (10 min). Aural recognition.
Sight-sing 5 short melodies daily (use solfège).

WEEK 2: Harmonic dictation practice. Identify cadences first, then full progression.
Practice 1 figured bass + 1 Roman numeral part-writing daily.

WEEK 3: Practice TIMED full sections from past exams.
Sight-sing daily, RECORD yourself, listen back for pitch accuracy.

WEEK 4: Take 1-2 full practice exams. Review weak areas only.
Light practice the day before — don't burn out.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ ~50%: intervals, key sigs, basic chord ID solid.	MCQ ~65%: 7th chord inversions, secondary dominants, cadence ID by ear.	MCQ ~80%: chromatic harmony, modulation, modes by ear.
Dictation: capture shape + rhythm + first/last note.	Dictation: most pitches + rhythm correct; cadence identified.	Dictation: all pitches + secondary dominants + modulations.
Part-writing: correct chords; some voice-leading errors.	Part-writing: clean voice leading; correct inversions.	Part-writing: graceful voice leading + secondary dominants worked in.
Sight-sing: diatonic with pitch slips, steady tempo.	Sight-sing: accurate diatonic + small chromatic.	Sight-sing: fluent chromatic + modulating melodies.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ Intervals: count number + quality (P/M/m/A/d) reliably.
- ✓ All key signatures memorized via circle of fifths.
- ✓ Triad qualities: M/m/dim/aug by sound + score.
- ✓ Time signatures + simple/compound meter ID.
- ✓ Sing tonic chord BEFORE sight-singing to anchor.
- ✓ Don't double the leading tone.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ Seventh chord inversions + figured bass numbers.
- ✓ Cadence types: PAC vs IAC vs half vs deceptive.
- ✓ Voice-leading rules: no parallels, resolve LT up, resolve 7ths down.
- ✓ Period structure: antecedent (HC) → consequent (PAC).
- ✓ Sight-sing with confident chromatic notes.
- ✓ Identify secondary dominants by accidental.

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ Modes by sound + characteristic note (Dorian, Mixolydian especially).
- ✓ Identify modulation in harmonic dictation.
- ✓ Spell + use Neapolitan + augmented 6th chords.
- ✓ Pivot chord modulation in part-writing.
- ✓ Sight-sing modulating melodies fluently.
- ✓ Phrygian half cadence + sentence structure recognition.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: TONAL ANCHORING. AP Music Theory rewards students who think IN A KEY rather than note-by-note. Every melody, every chord, every interval — locate it relative to TONIC (do or 1). When sight-singing, don't think "up a P5" — think "sol." When taking dictation, hear chords as "V" or "vi" not "G major" or "A minor." When voice-leading, see degree 7 as "the leading tone that wants to resolve up."

Tonal/functional thinking is the single skill separating 3s from 5s. Practice with that lens daily.

If you do nothing else: build daily aural skills + sight-sing practice from week 1; review part-writing rules in the last weeks. AP Music Theory cannot be crammed.

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